SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM

COMMON BUDDHIST FOUNDATION → TRADITION TAXONOMY AND FOUR-SCHOOL → PRACTICAL AND DOCTRINAL MIDDLE → TWELVE-LINKED DEPENDENT ORIGINATION → MOMENTARINESS AND NO-SELF → ACTION AND MORAL CONSEQUENCE

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ○ SUBORDINATE EXTRA ◆ APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g15 and all prior artifacts unchanged

00

STAGE 00 COMMON BUDDHIST FOUNDATION

COMMON BUDDHIST FOUNDATION · COMMON THERAPEUTIC CORE SUFFERING (DUḤKHA) · ORIGIN (TṚṢṆĀ/AVIDYĀ) · CESSATION (NIRVĀṆA) · EIGHTFOLD PATH THREE MARKS · SUFFERING (DUḤKHA) · ANĀTMAN DEPENDENT ORIGINATION SUPPLIES THE MIDDLE PATH (MADHYAMĀ PRATIPAD) · NEITHER ETERNAL SUBSTANCE NOR CAUSELESS ANNIHILATION LATER SCHOOLS DISAGREE

COMMON THERAPEUTIC CORE suffering (duḥkha) → origin (tṛṣṇā/avidyā) → cessation (nirvāṇa) → eightfold path three

suffering (duḥkha) → **anātman dependent origination supplies the Middle Path (madhyamā pratipad)** → **neither eternal substance nor causeless annihilation later schools disagree about what exists and**

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- COMMON THERAPEUTIC CORE suffering (duḥkha) → origin (tṛṣṇā/avidyā) → cessation (nirvāṇa) → eightfold path three marks: anitya
- suffering (duḥkha)

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- anātman dependent origination supplies the Middle Path (madhyamā pratipad)
- neither eternal substance nor causeless annihilation later schools disagree about what exists and

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- how it is known, not about the need to end ignorance and craving.
- COMMON THERAPEUTIC CORE suffering (duḥkha) → origin (tṛṣṇā/avidyā) → cessation (nirvāṇa) → eightfold path three marks: anitya

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: neither eternal substance nor causeless annihilation later schools disagree about what exists and how it is known, not about the need to end ignorance and craving.

01

STAGE 01 TRADITION TAXONOMY AND FOUR-SCHOOL MAPPING

TRADITION TAXONOMY AND FOUR-SCHOOL MAPPING · EARLY BUDDHISM · COMMON DIAGNOSTIC CORE BEFORE LATER SCHOOL SYSTEMS · PĀLI TIPIṬAKA + ARHAT IDEAL: ONE SURVIVING EARLY SCHOOL · MAHĀYĀNA-APPLIED, HISTORICALLY LOADED LABEL; NOT A THERAVĀDA SYNONYM · BODHISATTVA PATH TO COMPLETE BUDDHAHOOD FOR BEINGS · VAIBHĀṢIKA + SAUTRĀNTIKA · SARVĀSTIVĀDA-RELATED NON-MAHĀYĀNA POSITIONS

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EVALUATION / TRAP
EARLY BUDDHISM — common diagnostic core before later school systems	HĪNAYĀNA — Mahāyāna-applied, historically loaded label; not a Theravāda synonym	Vaibhāṣika + Sautrāntika — Sarvāstivāda-related non-Mahāyāna positions
THERAVĀDA — Pāli Tipiṭaka + arhat ideal; one surviving early school	MAHĀYĀNA — bodhisattva path to complete Buddhahood for beings	Yogācāra + Mādhyamika — Mahāyāna philosophical traditions four-school matrix = philosophical doxography, not complete institutional history

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

- EARLY BUDDHISM — common diagnostic core before later school systems
- THERAVĀDA — Pāli Tipiṭaka + arhat ideal; one surviving early school

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- HĪNAYĀNA — Mahāyāna-applied, historically loaded label; not a Theravāda synonym
- MAHĀYĀNA — bodhisattva path to complete Buddhahood for beings

EVALUATION / TRAP

- Vaibhāṣika + Sautrāntika — Sarvāstivāda-related non-Mahāyāna positions
- Yogācāra + Mādhyamika — Mahāyāna philosophical traditions four-school matrix = philosophical doxography, not complete institutional history

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Yogācāra + Mādhyamika → Mahāyāna philosophical traditions four-school matrix = philosophical doxography, not complete institutional history.

02

STAGE 02 PRACTICAL AND DOCTRINAL MIDDLE PATH

PRACTICAL AND DOCTRINAL MIDDLE PATH · MIDDLE PATH (MADHYAMĀ PRATIPAD; PALI · MAJJHIMĀ PAṬIPADĀ) PRACTICAL EXTREMES · SENSUAL INDULGENCE X SELF-MORTIFICATION POSITIVE ROUTE · NOBLE EIGHTFOLD PATH (ĀRYAṢṬĀṄGAMĀRGA) WISDOM + ETHICAL DISCIPLINE + · ETERNALISM X ANNIHILATIONISM DEPENDENT ORIGINATION PRESERVES CONDITIONED CONTINUITY WITHOUT · FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS

MIDDLE PATH (MADHYAMĀ PRATIPAD

PALI: MAJJHIMĀ PAṬIPADĀ) practical extremes: sensual indulgence X self-mortification positive route → Noble Eightfold Path → **Four Noble Truths → cause → cessation → path → liberation**

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- MIDDLE PATH (MADHYAMĀ PRATIPAD
- PALI: MAJJHIMĀ PAṬIPADĀ) practical extremes: sensual indulgence X self-mortification positive route → Noble Eightfold Path (āryāṣṭāṅgamārga) wisdom +

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- Four Noble Truths → cause → cessation → path → liberation
- MIDDLE PATH (MADHYAMĀ PRATIPAD

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- PALI: MAJJHIMĀ PAṬIPADĀ) practical extremes: sensual indulgence X self-mortification positive route → Noble Eightfold Path (āryāṣṭāṅgamārga) wisdom +
- Four Noble Truths → cause → cessation → path → liberation

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Four Noble Truths → cause → cessation → path → liberation.

03

STAGE 03 TWELVE-LINKED DEPENDENT ORIGINATION

TWELVE-LINKED DEPENDENT ORIGINATION · IGNORANCE (AVIDYĀ) · IGNORANCE CONDITIONS FORMATIONS; CRAVING AND GRASPING RENEW BECOMING · "WHEN THIS IS, THAT COMES TO BE; WITH CESSATION · END IGNORANCE (AVIDYĀ)/TṚṢṆĀ · BREAK APPROPRIATION · END REBIRTH-DUḤKHA. · THREE-LIFE READING

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- ignorance (avidyā) → saṃskāra → vijñāna → nāma-rūpa → ṣaḍāyatana → sparśa
- vedanā → tṛṣṇā → upādāna → bhava → jāti → jarā-maraṇa
- IGNORANCE conditions formations; craving and grasping renew becoming

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- "When this is, that comes to be
- with cessation of this, that ceases" reverse order: end ignorance (avidyā)/tṛṣṇā → break appropriation → end rebirth-duḥkha.
- THREE-LIFE READING: past causes → present effects/causes → future results

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- PRESENT-PROCESS READING: contact → feeling → craving → appropriation now
- CAUTION: diagnostic structure, not an absolutely first cause or one rigid chronology

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CAUTION: diagnostic structure, not an absolutely first cause or one rigid chronology.

04

STAGE 04 MOMENTARINESS AND NO-SELF

MOMENTARINESS AND NO-SELF · DEPENDENT ORIGINATION (PRATĪTYASAMUTPĀDA) · CONDITIONED THINGS ARISE AND PERISH · (KṢAṆIKAVĀDA) CAUSAL EFFICACY BELONGS TO THE MOMENT; NO UNCHANGED · PERSON ANALYSIS · FIVE AGGREGATES (SKANDHAS) RŪPA · VIJÑĀNA NONE IS PERMANENT, INDEPENDENT OR "MINE" · NO PERMANENT SELF (NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA) CONTINUITY

DEPENDENT ORIGINATION (pratītyasamutpāda) → conditioned things arise and perish → MOMENTARINESS

(kṣaṇikavāda) causal efficacy belongs to the moment; no unchanged bearer is required → **PERSON ANALYSIS → five aggregates (skandhas) rūpa** → **vijñāna none is permanent, independent or "mine" → NO PERMANENT SELF (nairātmyavāda) continuity = causal**

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- DEPENDENT ORIGINATION (pratītyasamutpāda) → conditioned things arise and perish → MOMENTARINESS
- (kṣaṇikavāda) causal efficacy belongs to the moment; no unchanged bearer is required

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- PERSON ANALYSIS → five aggregates (skandhas) rūpa
- vijñāna none is permanent, independent or "mine" → NO PERMANENT SELF (nairātmyavāda) continuity = causal series, like flame-to-flame

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- identity is neither strict sameness nor total unrelatedness.
- DEPENDENT ORIGINATION (pratītyasamutpāda) → conditioned things arise and perish → MOMENTARINESS

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: PERSON ANALYSIS → five aggregates (skandhas) rūpa | vedanā | saṃjñā | saṃskāra | vijñāna none is permanent, independent or "mine" → NO PERMANENT SELF (nairātmyavāda) continuity = causal series, like flame-to-flame; identity is neither strict sameness nor total unrelatedness.

05

STAGE 05 ACTION AND MORAL CONSEQUENCE (KARMA), MEMORY AND CESSATION OF CONDITIONED SUFFERING (NIRVĀṆA)

ACTION AND MORAL CONSEQUENCE (KARMA), MEMORY AND CESSATION OF · NO ENDURING SELF (ĀTMAN), YET CAUSAL RESPONSIBILITY INTENTION AT · CONDITIONS STREAM · FRUIT AT T2 MEMORY · LATER COGNITION CAUSALLY CONDITIONED BY EARLIER EXPERIENCE REBIRTH · ONE PSYCHO-PHYSICAL SERIES CONDITIONS ANOTHER, WITHOUT SOUL-TRANSMIGRATION OBJECTION · IF AGENT PERISHES, ANOTHER RECEIVES RESULT REPLY · SUCCESSOR IS NEITHER IDENTICAL NOR WHOLLY DIFFERENT; CAUSAL APPROPRIATION

NO ENDURING SELF (ātman), YET CAUSAL RESPONSIBILITY intention at t1 → conditions stream → fruit → **causal appropriation connects cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) = cessation of greed, hatred and delusion**

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- NO ENDURING SELF (ātman), YET CAUSAL RESPONSIBILITY intention at t1 → conditions stream → fruit at t2 memory
- causal appropriation connects cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) = cessation of greed, hatred and delusion, not destruction of

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- NO ENDURING SELF (ātman), YET CAUSAL RESPONSIBILITY intention at t1 → conditions stream → fruit at t2 memory
- causal appropriation connects cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) = cessation of greed, hatred and delusion, not destruction of

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- NO ENDURING SELF (ātman), YET CAUSAL RESPONSIBILITY intention at t1 → conditions stream → fruit at t2 memory
- causal appropriation connects cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) = cessation of greed, hatred and delusion, not destruction of

MECHANISM / VERDICT — NO ENDURING SELF (ātman), YET CAUSAL RESPONSIBILITY intention at t1 → conditions stream → fruit at t2 memory = later cognition causally conditioned by earlier experience rebirth = one psycho-physical series conditions another, without soul-transmigration objection: if agent perishes, another receives result reply: successor is neither identical nor wholly different; causal appropriation connects cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) = cessation of greed, hatred and delusion, not destruction of a substance-self.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: if agent perishes, another receives result reply: successor is neither identical nor wholly different; causal appropriation connects cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) = cessation of greed, hatred and delusion, not destruction of a substance-self.

06

STAGE 06 ABHIDHARMA SCHOOL FORK

ABHIDHARMA SCHOOL FORK · BUDDHIST REALITY · KNOWLEDGE DEBATE · NON-MAHĀYĀNA ABHIDHARMA MAHĀYĀNA · VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA YOGĀCĀRA MĀDHYAMIKA EXTERNAL EXTERNAL OBJECTS COGNITION EMPTINESS · SCHOOL LABELS MARK EPISTEMIC/ONTOLOGICAL POSITIONS, NOT FOUR PATHS TO

BUDDHIST REALITY / KNOWLEDGE DEBATE

NON-MAHĀYĀNA ABHIDHARMA MAHĀYĀNA → **Vaibhāṣika Sautrāntika Yogācāra Mādhyamika external external objects cognition emptiness of dharmas inferred** → **from ideas only all intrinsic nature (svabhāva) directly and causal effects perceived**

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- BUDDHIST REALITY / KNOWLEDGE DEBATE
- NON-MAHĀYĀNA ABHIDHARMA MAHĀYĀNA

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- Vaibhāṣika Sautrāntika Yogācāra Mādhyamika external external objects cognition emptiness of dharmas inferred
- from ideas only all intrinsic nature (svabhāva) directly and causal effects perceived

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- SCHOOL LABELS MARK EPISTEMIC/ONTOLOGICAL POSITIONS, NOT FOUR PATHS TO MIX.
- BUDDHIST REALITY / KNOWLEDGE DEBATE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: SCHOOL LABELS MARK EPISTEMIC/ONTOLOGICAL POSITIONS, NOT FOUR PATHS TO MIX.

07

STAGE 07 VAIBHĀṢIKA AND SAUTRĀNTIKA

VAIBHĀṢIKA AND SAUTRĀNTIKA · ISSUE VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA EXTERNAL OBJECT REAL DHARMAS REAL MOMENTARY · DHARMAS EXIST ONLY PRESENT CAUSAL MOMENT STRESSED COGNITION GRASPS · SAUTRĀNTIKA ARGUMENT · OBJECT-MOMENT IS GONE WHEN AWARENESS OCCURS · THEREFORE COGNITION PRESENTS AN IMAGE, FROM WHICH EXTERNAL CAUSE · REPRESENTATIVE REALISM MUST EXPLAIN CORRESPONDENCE.

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EVALUATION / TRAP
ISSUE VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA external object real dharmas real momentary causes access direct perception inferred from mental	SAUTRĀNTIKA ARGUMENT: object-moment is gone when awareness occurs	PRESSURE: representative realism must explain correspondence.
image past/future sarvāstivāda: dharmas exist only present causal moment stressed cognition grasps object represents object	therefore cognition presents an image, from which external cause is inferred.	ISSUE VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA external object real dharmas real momentary causes access direct perception inferred from mental

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

- ISSUE VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA external object real dharmas real momentary causes access direct perception inferred from mental
- image past/future sarvāstivāda: dharmas exist only present causal moment stressed cognition grasps object represents object

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- SAUTRĀNTIKA ARGUMENT: object-moment is gone when awareness occurs
- therefore cognition presents an image, from which external cause is inferred.

EVALUATION / TRAP

- PRESSURE: representative realism must explain correspondence.
- ISSUE VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA external object real dharmas real momentary causes access direct perception inferred from mental

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: therefore cognition presents an image, from which external cause is inferred.

08

STAGE 08 YOGĀCĀRA AND MĀDHYAMIKA

YOGĀCĀRA AND MĀDHYAMIKA · CONSCIOUSNESS-ONLY DOCTRINE (VIJÑĀNAVĀDA) MĀDHYAMIKA · EMPTINESS (ŚŪNYATĀ) SUBJECT-OBJECT DUALITY IS CONSTRUCTED ALL THINGS LACK · REPRESENTATION-ONLY DEPENDENT ARISING · EMPTINESS STORE-CONSCIOUSNESS (ĀLAYA-VIJÑĀNA) STORES BĪJA TENDENCIES TWO TRUTHS · PARAMĀRTHA THREE NATURES · PARIKALPITA, TETRALEMMA REJECTS IS · IS-NOT PARATANTRA, PARINIṢPANNA BOTH

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- YOGĀCĀRA / CONSCIOUSNESS-ONLY DOCTRINE (vijñānavāda) MĀDHYAMIKA / EMPTINESS (śūnyatā) subject-object duality is constructed all things lack intrinsic
- nature (svabhāva) vijñapti-mātra: representation-only dependent arising = emptiness store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) stores bīja tendencies two truths: saṃvṛti /

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- paramārtha three natures: parikalpita, tetralemma rejects is / is-not paratantra, pariniṣpanna both / neither as ultimate capture
- CONVERGENCE: dissolve reification

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- DIFFERENCE: Yogācāra privileges purified cognition, while Mādhyamika empties even consciousness and emptiness itself.
- YOGĀCĀRA / CONSCIOUSNESS-ONLY DOCTRINE (vijñānavāda) MĀDHYAMIKA / EMPTINESS (śūnyatā) subject-object duality is constructed all things lack intrinsic

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CONVERGENCE: dissolve reification; DIFFERENCE: Yogācāra privileges purified cognition, while Mādhyamika empties even consciousness and emptiness itself.

09

STAGE 09 CRITIQUE AND PYQ ANSWER SPINE

CRITIQUE AND PYQ ANSWER SPINE · FLUX CANNOT EXPLAIN CONTINUITY · ANĀTMAN WEAKENS AGENCY · EMPTINESS (ŚŪNYATĀ) IS NIHILISM · CAUSAL SERIES · DEPENDENT RESPONSIBILITY · EMPTINESS DENIES SELF-NATURE, NOT FUNCTION · ANSWER RAIL COMMON CORE

OBJECTIONS: flux cannot explain continuity → **anātman weakens agency** → **emptiness (śūnyatā) is nihilism** → REPLIES: causal series → **dependent responsibility**

DOCTRINE / CLAIM

- OBJECTIONS: flux cannot explain continuity
- anātman weakens agency
- emptiness (śūnyatā) is nihilism
- REPLIES: causal series

OBJECTION / PRESSURE

- dependent responsibility
- emptiness denies self-nature, not function
- ANSWER RAIL common core → twelve links → momentariness → five-skandha no-self
- action and moral consequence (karma)/memory reply → four-school fork → exact school comparison

REPLY / RESIDUAL

- objection/reply → qualified verdict
- CLOSE: Buddhism replaces substance with conditioned process
- its schools progressively debate whether external dharmas, cognition, or any intrinsic nature can be retained.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE: Buddhism replaces substance with conditioned process; its schools progressively debate whether external dharmas, cognition, or any intrinsic nature can be retained.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · LAYER-PLACEMENT NOTE · LAYER-PLACEMENT NOTE ALL LAYER 3 MATERIAL FROM THE LEGACY · IT SHOULD REFINE A CORE ANSWER, NOT DISPLACE THE · LAYER 3 - ADVANCED ADVANCED DERIVATION AND SCHOOL DIVERGENCE · IT DIAGNOSES THE STRUCTURE OF CONDITIONED BECOMING HERE AND · THIS AVOIDS ETERNALISM BECAUSE NO UNCHANGED SELF GROUNDS THE · THE DOCTRINE SUPPORTS DIFFERENT ONTOLOGICAL CONCLUSIONS.

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESS

- Layer-placement note
- Layer-placement note All Layer 3 material from the legacy complete session is retained here after practice.
- It should refine a core answer, not displace the printed syllabus.
- LAYER 3 - ADVANCED Advanced derivation and school divergence Dependent origination is not a search for the universe's first cause.

ADVANCED OBJECTION

- It diagnoses the structure of conditioned becoming here and now.
- This avoids eternalism because no unchanged self grounds the process, and avoids annihilationism because causal continuity remains.
- The doctrine supports different ontological conclusions.
- Mādhyamika argues that whatever depends on conditions lacks intrinsic nature (svabhāva) and is therefore empty.

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

- Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika instead emphasise that causally functioning conditioned events are real.
- Their disagreement concerns ultimate status, not whether dependent arising occurs.
- The strongest challenge is regress: if every event is conditioned, what explains the chain as a whole?
- The Buddhist reply is therapeutic and structural rather than foundational—the task is to

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels